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IT IS QUITE TELLING THAT THE ONLY INDIAN PLAYERS TO HAVE SCORED MORE THAN 100 RUNS AND PICKED FIVE OR MORE WICKETS THIS SEASON ARE HARDIK PANDYA, RAVINDRA JADEJA AND AXAR PATEL

For a sport contested between 22 players since time immemorial, the addition of two members to the mix has almost irrevocably altered the lexicon of cricket. If the Indian Premier League (IPL) was the disruptor of international competition, the Impact Player rule has only further fed into the lore of the cash-rich league's subversive image.

After 54 matches, the average run rate of the ongoing tournament stands at a whopping 9.58, the highest ever for any T20 series or

competition involving more than four matches. The fact that this landmark has coincided with the Impact Player rule's second iteration is not a mere coincidence. Nine of the 10 highest team totals in the IPL have come following the introduction of this innovation in 2023.

Though Sunrisers Hyderabad tops the charts with its 287-run total, the 250-run benchmark has been breached with abandon — eight times — this season. A 262-run target has been dismantled with eight balls to spare, and T20 batting, which seemed to have entered uncharted territory initially, has forayed into the stratosphere.

Understandably, the bowlers are left to feel like collateral in a spectacle

that seems increasingly tailor-made for batters and fans. And while the skills of the likes of Jasprit Bumrah and Sunil Narine stand out even amidst this carnage, all-rounders have been handed the shorter end of the stick.

By allowing teams to swap one player for another at any point in the match, the sport has increasingly come to revolve around specialists, limiting the role of those with the ability to add value with both bat and ball in varying degrees.

The Impact Player rule affords the team batting first the luxury to field